Vibe Practice Management — Setup

Enable, sign in, and configure Vibe Practice Management on your Vibe Appliance.

Vibe Appliance setup guide · built 2026-08-31 · generated from the app's manifest · KisaesDevLab/Vibe-Appliance

1. What this app is

Practice management for the firm: time tracking, billing and invoicing, retainers, proposals and engagement letters, WIP reporting, a client portal, and document intake.

App id (slug)	`vibe-time-billing`
Uses	the appliance's shared postgres, redis — nothing separate to install
Data lives in	database `vibe_time_billing_db` inside the appliance's Postgres — covered by your Duplicati backups and by the automatic pre-update dump

2. Before you enable it

- The appliance itself must be installed and healthy — see the **Vibe Appliance setup guide** first if you haven't done that yet.
- Each running app uses memory. Two or three apps fit a 2 GB server; for all of them plan on 4 GB or more.
- If the card shows an image not published badge, the app's build isn't available yet — the Enable button stays off until it is.

3. Enable the app

1. Open the admin console and scroll to **Apps**.
2. On the **Vibe Practice Management** card, click **Enable**.
3. Watch the badge: `not-installed → enabling… → running`. This usually takes a minute or two (first enable pulls the app's images).

Behind the button, the appliance creates the app’s database and a restricted database user, writes the app's configuration file from a template, starts its containers, and only reports **running** once the app's own health check answers that it is fully ready. If enabling fails, the card shows the error with a recovery hint — fix the cause and click Enable again; re-running is always safe.

4. Open it and sign in

Domain mode	`https://practice.<your-domain>/` — this app is served at the root of its own subdomain (it cannot be path-mounted). The appliance provisions the DNS/tunnel route automatically when you enable it.
LAN / Tailscale	Use the emergency port (next section) — a root-served app has no path URL on the shared hostname.
client portal	`https://portal.<your-domain>/` (domain mode)

The exact live URL for your install is always shown on this app's card in the admin console — use that if in doubt.

Open the app URL. Sign in with username `admin@appliance.local`. The one-time default password is shown in the admin console under **First-login info** — it is not printed here so this guide never goes stale.

5. Setup on Windows

There is nothing to install on Windows for this app — it runs on the appliance server, and you use it from a browser (Microsoft Edge or Chrome, as your firm prefers). What follows is the Windows side of reaching it in each mode.

- **Domain mode:** just open the URL from the previous section. The certificate is real, so there is nothing to click through.
- **LAN mode:** recent Windows 10 and 11 resolve `<host>.local` addresses out of the box, but some office networks and VPN clients block that discovery traffic. If the `.local` address doesn't load, use the server's IP address instead: `http://<server-ip>:5178/` (this app's LAN address is its emergency port). The exact working URL is always shown on this app's card in the admin console.
- **Tailscale mode:** install the Tailscale app for Windows from `tailscale.com/download`, sign in to the firm's tailnet, and the tailnet URL from the section above works. The Tailscale icon in the system tray shows whether you're connected.
- **Bookmark it:** once the right URL loads, save it as a browser favorite (Ctrl+D) — or let your IT person pin it via a browser shortcut on each staff desktop.

6. Settings

Everything required (database, cache, secrets, URLs) is generated automatically when you enable the app. The settings below are the ones you may need to fill in yourself. Find them in the admin console under **Settings**, on the tab named in the left column.

Network tab

SETTING	WHAT TO ENTER
Subdomain	The <subdomain> in <subdomain>.<your-domain> for the staff app. Leave blank for the default (practice). Lowercase letters, digits, and dashes; no dots. Saving re-renders routing and re-provisions the Cloudflare Tunnel; the app briefly restarts.

Application tab

SETTING	WHAT TO ENTER
Document storage backend	mock is evaluation-only — uploaded documents are NOT durable. For production, create a Backblaze B2 bucket (firm-owned), fill in the B2 fields below, and set this to b2. The app restarts on save.
B2 endpoint	From the B2 bucket's details page, e.g. https://s3.us-west-004.backblazeb2.com.
B2 region	The region segment of the endpoint, e.g. us-west-004.
B2 bucket	A private bucket the firm owns. The app never shares these credentials with third parties.
B2 key ID	Create an application key restricted to the bucket above.
B2 application key secret — stored in the app's env file, never displayed again	The secret half of the application key. Stored in the per-app env file (mode 600).

Email & SMS tab

SETTING	WHAT TO ENTER
SMTP host	Sign-in emails (magic links, one-time codes), invoices, and client notifications all go through this relay. Required before first login.
SMTP port	587 for STARTTLS (typical), 465 for implicit TLS, 25 for plain relays.
SMTP username	Leave blank for an unauthenticated relay.
SMTP password secret — stored in the app's env file, never displayed again	Stored in the per-app env file (mode 600).
Mail from address	Shown on sign-in, invoice, and portal emails. Use an address your SMTP relay is allowed to send as.

7. Notes for this app

> **Document storage starts in evaluation mode.** The app ships with `STORAGE_PROVIDER=mock` so your first enable succeeds — but mock storage is **throwaway**: uploaded documents are not durable. Before storing real client documents, create a firm-owned Backblaze B2 bucket, fill in the five B2 fields on the **Application** settings tab, and switch the storage backend to `b2`. The app restarts on save.

The client portal is a separate surface (`portal.<your-domain>` in domain mode) with its own sign-in realm — staff sessions and client sessions never mix. Portal magic-link and payment flows require HTTPS, so they will not work over the plain-HTTP emergency port; that port is for staff recovery access only.

8. Updates and rollback

- When a newer build is available, the card shows an **update available** badge. Click **Update**.
- Before updating, the appliance takes a database backup automatically. If the updated app fails its health check, it is rolled back to the previous version — and the **Roll back** button lets you do the same by hand.
- Updates are never automatic; nothing changes until you click.

9. If something goes wrong

- **Run the doctor first.** Admin console → **Doctor** → Run (or `sudo vibe doctor` on the server). It names the failing check and the fix.
- **Read the card.** Errors on the app card include a recovery hint; the output panel under the buttons shows the last action's log.
- **Emergency access.** If the normal URL is down but the app itself is running, `http://<server-ip>:5178/` reaches it directly, bypassing the web front end. Plain HTTP — use it from the LAN or Tailscale only, for getting back on your feet, not for daily work. (Staff emergency access only — portal magic-link and payment flows require HTTPS cookies and won't work over the plain-HTTP emergency port.) The client portal surface has its own emergency port: `http://<server-ip>:5179/`.
- **Disable / Enable** from the card restarts the app cleanly. Disabling never deletes data.
- Still stuck? `docs/TROUBLESHOOTING.md` in the appliance repository is keyed by symptom.